

The Witness

A thakur **borrowed** a large sum of money from a bania and despite repeated reminders failed to repay it. One day, the bania went to the thakur's house when he was **entertaining** guests and demanded the money. The **embarrassed** thakur promised to come to his place the next day with the money. But he had no **intention** of repaying the loan. Instead, he wanted to take **revenge** against the bania for **humiliating** him in front of his guests.

So one evening, he **waylaid** the man on a **deserted stretch** of road. "No one can insult me and get away with it!" he said, **drawing out** his sword.

The bania **thought fast**. "I was expecting you would do something like this," he said. "I've left a letter with my wife. If I do not return home by nightfall, she will take the letter to the king. The letter details the business transaction between us and the steps I took to recover the money. It also expresses the fear that you might do me some harm."

The thakur lowered his sword. He knew that the bania could be **bluffing** but he did not want to **take a chance**. The king was known to be **harsh** on **defaulters** and murderers.

"I'll **spare** your **worthless** life," he said finally, "but I'll chop off your nose. That'll teach you a lesson you'll never forget."

"If I **write off** your loan, will you forgive me?" asked the bania.



"I might," said the thakur **guardedly**, "but you must give me a receipt to say I've paid you in full. I don't trust you."

"I'll make out a receipt right away," said the bania, **hastily** opening his bundle of books. "But we'll require a witness."

"No witness!" cried the thakur. "Just give me a receipt to say that I've paid you in full."

"The receipt has no value unless there is a witness," said the bania. "Why don't we make that old banyan tree a witness?"

The thakur **reasoned** that there could be no harm in making a banyan tree a witness. It could not reveal the circumstances in which the receipt was made. So he agreed. They stood under the banyan

tree and the bania wrote out the receipt and gave it to the thakur, who pocketed it and **went away**, feeling very **pleased** with himself.

But the very next day, he received a **summons** from the king. When he went to the king's palace, he found the bania there.

"Did you borrow money from this man?" asked the king.

"I did," said the thakur.

"Why haven't you repaid it?"

"But I have," said the thakur and triumphantly taking out the receipt from his pocket, **handed it over** to the king.

"So your witness was a banyan tree," said the king, looking at the receipt.

"Yes," said the thakur, "there was nobody else there."

"So you **admit accosting** him in a deserted spot?"

"No, no," said the thakur, **panicking**. "I... I... just happened to meet him there."

"Anyway this receipt is useless," said the king. "It does not carry this man's signature, only the witness's."

"What!" **gasped** the thakur, taking the paper from the king's hand. He **stared** at it and **turned pale**. Instead of putting his signature at the bottom, the bania had **scribbled**: "Banyan Tree".

Vocabulary

1. **Borrow** (verb) – take on loan, obtain, receive, get उधार लेना
2. **Entertain** (verb) – host, amuse, engage, receive आतिथ्य करना
3. **Embarrassed** (adjective) – ashamed, humiliated, uncomfortable, self-conscious शर्मिंदा
4. **Intention** (noun) – purpose, aim, goal, plan इरादा
5. **Revenge** (noun) – retaliation, vengeance, payback, retribution बदला
6. **Humiliate** (verb) – insult, degrade, disgrace, shame अपमानित करना
7. **Waylay** (verb) – ambush, intercept, attack, pounce घात लगाना
8. **Deserted** (adjective) – empty, abandoned, lonely, desolate सुनसान
9. **Stretch** (noun) – span, distance, extent, length हिस्सा
10. **Draw out** (phrasal verb) – take out, pull out, extract, remove निकालना
11. **Think fast** (phrase) – react quickly, make a quick decision झटपट सोचना
12. **Bluff** (verb) – deceive, pretend, mislead, fake धोखा देना
13. **Take a chance** (phrase) – risk it, try something uncertain जोखिम लेना
14. **Harsh** (adjective) – cruel, severe, strict, stern कठोर
15. **Defaulter** (noun) – debtor, nonpayer, offender, violator बकायेदार
16. **Spare** (verb) – save, pardon, forgive, excuse बख्श देना
17. **Worthless** (adjective) – useless, valueless, insignificant, trashy मूल्यहीन
18. **Write off** (phrasal verb) – cancel, forgive, discharge, nullify माफ़ करना
19. **Guardedly** (adverb) – cautiously, carefully, warily, skeptically सावधानीपूर्वक
20. **Hastily** (adverb) – quickly, hurriedly, speedily, rashly जल्दी में
21. **Reason** (verb) – argue, justify, explain, deduce तर्क करना
22. **Go away** (phrasal verb) – leave, depart, exit, walk off चला जाना
23. **Pleased** (adjective) – happy, content, satisfied, glad प्रसन्न
24. **Summon** (noun) – order, call, notice, command समन
25. **Hand over** (phrasal verb) – give, deliver, pass, transfer सौंपना
26. **Admit** (verb) – confess, acknowledge, accept, concede स्वीकार करना
27. **Accost** (verb) – confront, approach, stop, challenge रोकना

28. **Panick** (verb) – become terrified, get scared, lose control, freak out घबरा जाना

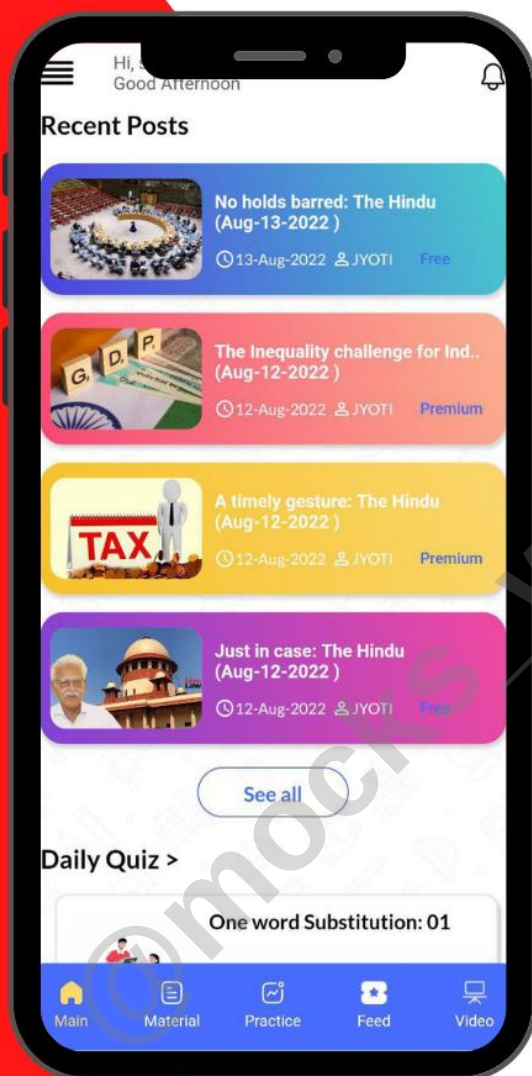
29. **Gasp** (verb) – breathe hard, exclaim, pant, struggle to breathe हांफना

30. **Stare at** (verb) – gaze, look fixedly, ogle, peer घूरना

31. **Turn pale** (phrase) – lose color from face due to shock or fear चेहरा पीला पड़ जाना

32. **Scribble** (verb) – scrawl, write messily, jot, scratch लिख डालना

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